THE GREAT RUSH FOR ROTORCRAFT

AS INDIA FACES AN UNPRECEDENTED DEMAND FOR BOTH MILITARY AND CIVIL HELICOPTERS, PRIVATE FIRMS ARE TYING UP WITH FOREIGN COMPANIES TO MEET IT. IT COULD BE AN IMPORTANT MOMENT FOR INDIA'S AMBITIONS AS A SELF-RELIANT AEROSPACE BASE

By PRADIP R. SAGAR

India is heading into a helicopter supercycle—and this time, much of the demand is to be met not through foreign procurement, but via foreign partnership with top Indian defence firms. That is because a majority of the Indian military's current rotary-wing inventory, inducted between the 1960s and 1990s, is nearing obsolescence. With demand for over 1,000 helicopters over the next decade, the armed forces have to replace a rapidly ageing fleet and build the capacity to meet operational needs across land, sea and high-altitude frontiers. From light utility helicopters supplying troops in extreme Himalayan conditions to multi-role and maritime platforms supporting an expanding security footprint, rotary aviation is becoming central to India's defence modernisation.

In a parallel development, the need for regional connectivity and emergency services has widened the market in the civilian sector as well. This has made helicopters critical infrastructure rather than niche assets for use by the rich and VIPs.

The surge in demand has seen global manufacturers scrambling for a piece of the action—Airbus Helicopters (France), Leonardo S.p.A. (Italy), Bell Textron (US) and Sikorsky (US) are deepening their footprint in India. Partnerships between Airbus Helicopters and Tata Advanced Systems Limited (TASL) and Leonardo S.p.A. with Adani Defence & Aerospace signal a shift toward local manufacturing ecosystems.

Noting that India currently accounts for less than 2 per cent of the global helicopter market, Ashish Rajvanshi, CEO of Adani Defence, says meeting this demand will require a strong domestic ecosystem that combines the strengths of public sector institutions, private industry and global technology partners. "Our focus is on building long-term aerospace manufacturing capacity in India so that critical platforms can be designed and produced and sustained within our nation, contributing to the broader vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat," he says.

According to industry estimates, India's helicopter market is projected to grow from $1.58 billion (Rs 14,975 crore) in 2024 to $2.88 billion (Rs 27,296 crore) by 2032.

THE NEW CHOPPERS IN THE MAKING

India needs more than 1,000 military and civil helicopters worth over Rs 25,000 crore in the coming decade. These are the prominent ones to be made in India



H 160M

Twin-engine, multi-role helicopter ideal for maritime role, commando infiltration, anti-ship warfare etc. Has civil version
TOP SPEED: 315 kmph
RANGE: 880 km



MANUFACTURER: Airbus, France
INDIAN PARTNER: TASL, plans to offer the copter for the Naval Utility Helicopter (NUH) programme

ALH MkIII (Maritime Role)

